

# Who Must Agree

Bond authorisation rules as coalition requirements

Empirical sections and exhibits — working conference draft

Compiled 25 August 2026 from the committed analysis record (corpus package v3, frozen).

*Working conference draft. Every number traces to a committed results file (script-to-results map in `analysis/ANALYSIS_REVIEW.md`). [**PENDING**] marks claims held on a named data pass. The draft is frozen on corpus package v3. Sections 1 to 3 (theory and institutional framework) are maintained separately.*

Reading paragraphs under exhibits are drafting aids, marked strippable for submission.

## 4 · Data: seeing consent from statute to bond

The story this paper tells is simple. American local governments build schools, water systems and roads with borrowed money. In some states, for some kinds of government, the law says the voters must agree first. The empirical sections ask three questions in turn: how borrowing is actually authorised, and by whom (Section 5); what winning or losing that vote causes (Section 6); and what happens after a refusal (Section 7). Sections 8 and 9 ask where the requirement bites hardest and how it shapes what is proposed in the first place. Answering these questions takes three datasets, described here in the order the argument uses them.

**First, the borrowing: the official-statement corpus.** When a local government sells bonds, it publishes an official statement, a disclosure document describing the issue. The corpus assembled for this paper contains 258,762 such documents, covering 2005 to 2025, all fifty states and 43,030 issuers. Three things are read out of each document. The first is what was borrowed: the amount, and the security behind it, from **general-obligation (GO) debt**, backed by the government’s power to tax, to revenue bonds and leases, which are backed by user charges or appropriations and typically need no election. The second is what the money is for, with each project line classified into 118 functional activities. The third is the variable the paper turns on: **on whose authority the debt was issued**. An official statement must state the legal authority for the issue, so nearly every issue (93.7% of documents) can be coded as authorised by the voters, by the governing board, or directly by statute. Where voters authorised the issue, the document usually cites the election date, which allows the coding to be checked against actual election records; the checks are summarised in Appendix Table A13 and behave exactly as registry coverage predicts. Census survey data play two narrow supporting roles later on (a survivorship check and a bound on debt-free construction) and are introduced where used.

**Second, the rules.** Which governments must ask? A fifty-state panel codes, for every state and type of government, whether the default path to GO debt runs through a mandatory ballot, and at what threshold. The coding follows one definition throughout: a rule is **strict** when a government that wants to issue GO debt must, by default, put the question to an election at the polls. Rules that require only a town-meeting vote (New England), a referendum only if citizens petition for one (Mississippi, Tennessee, Wisconsin cities), or a vote only above a debt limit or for certain purposes, are coded non-strict: under all of them a government can normally borrow without facing an electorate. **[PENDING]** The panel is a first-pass machine coding, cross-validated against an independent hand coding, with a human verification pass in progress on the disputed cells; until it lands, every rule coefficient is read as an association, not a causal estimate, and each table note repeats this.

**Third, the elections.** Nine states publish administrative registries of local bond and tax elections (California, Texas, Wisconsin, Louisiana, North Carolina, Massachusetts, Minnesota, Illinois, Indiana). Compiled, these give 47,235 ballot measures, of which 40,924 are matched to their government in the Census of Governments, so that a vote can be joined to the same government’s later borrowing in the corpus. The causal design of Section 6 uses the subset where a statute, not a local choice, sets the pass threshold: **11,889 GO bond measures**, each with its yes share and its statutory threshold, so that a single **running variable**, the yes share minus the threshold, puts every measure on a common scale where zero is the pass/fail line. Table 1 summarises the frame and its restriction cascade. One registry caution matters for interpretation and is flagged where relevant: the registries differ in scope (Wisconsin’s covers school referenda only), so cross-state comparisons of what appears on ballots are never based on the registries

alone.

**Table 1:** Sample and summary statistics

| State (threshold)                         | N      | Mean yes | Passed | Median amount | Median electorate |
|-------------------------------------------|--------|----------|--------|---------------|-------------------|
| CA (55%)                                  | 1,715  | 62.423   | 0.809  | \$44.0m       | –                 |
| CA (66.7%)                                | 466    | 66.442   | 0.509  | \$20.0m       | –                 |
| LA (50%)                                  | 361    | 59.796   | 0.770  | –             | 1,357             |
| NC (50%)                                  | 278    | 65.843   | 0.914  | –             | 30,568            |
| TX (50%)                                  | 8,062  | 68.849   | 0.792  | \$15.0m       | 1,397             |
| WI (50%)                                  | 999    | 54.070   | 0.661  | \$12.4m       | 2,988             |
| All compiled referenda                    | 47,235 |          |        |               |                   |
| Matched to a Census government            | 40,924 |          |        |               |                   |
| At a genuine mandatory-ballot requirement | 23,577 |          |        |               |                   |
| GO regression-discontinuity frame         | 11,889 |          |        |               |                   |

*Panel B: the official-statement corpus (package v3)*

Documents: 258,762

Issuers: 43,030

Determination rate: 0.937

Mode shares (docs): voter / board / statutory: 0.195 / 0.666 / 0.063

New-money par: schools / municipal / county / special / township (\$B): 524 / 606 / 220 / 139 / 35

*Notes:* Panel A: the referendum frame by state and threshold (cells  $\geq 30$  measures); amounts where registries print them (CA/TX/WI); electorate = votes cast where counts exist (TX/WI/LA/NC; counts-unknown placeholder rows excluded). Restriction cascade beneath. Panel B: corpus package v3.

**Reading.** The frame spans three statutory thresholds; the corpus supplies the authorisation mode for 93.7 per cent of a quarter-million documents.

## 5 · Who must agree, and for what

This section establishes the descriptive foundation of the paper: who authorises local borrowing in practice, which public goods ever face a ballot, and whether the written rules actually govern behaviour. The central observation, developed as Fact 1 below, is that "who must agree" is not one institution. The same constitutional sentence lands on governments with utterly different escape routes, and that variation, not the text of the rule, is what organises everything the later sections find.

### 5.1 How borrowing is authorised: the menu, by type of government

Table 2 is the paper's descriptive anchor. For every type of local government, it shows who authorised the borrowed dollars (voters, the board, or statute) and what security stood behind them; Table 3 shows what the money was for.

Read together, the two tables say something the institutional literature tends to miss. **School districts are the voted sector of the local state.** Nearly two-thirds of their dollars are voter-authorised, four-fifths are GO debt, and essentially everything they borrow for is education. At the other pole, **municipalities are the unvoted sector:** barely a tenth of their dollars pass through an electorate, and the majority are revenue bonds backed by charges rather than taxes. Counties and special districts sit between, and townships look like small schools (mostly GO, substantially voted), a point Section 5.4 returns to.

**Table 2:** How local borrowing is authorised, by type of government

| Government type   | Issues | \$B | Authorised by (% of \$) |       |         | Security (% of \$) |         |       |
|-------------------|--------|-----|-------------------------|-------|---------|--------------------|---------|-------|
|                   |        |     | Voters                  | Board | Statute | GO                 | Revenue | Lease |
| School districts  | 30,486 | 525 | 63.4                    | 34.5  | 2.1     | 82.3               | 10.0    | 6.3   |
| Municipalities    | 24,246 | 606 | 11.3                    | 60.3  | 28.4    | 33.7               | 59.0    | 3.1   |
| Counties          | 6,928  | 219 | 16.9                    | 78.0  | 5.1     | 59.6               | 32.4    | 5.0   |
| Townships         | 3,587  | 35  | 38.0                    | 60.3  | 1.6     | 93.2               | 3.8     | 0.6   |
| Special districts | 9,148  | 180 | 26.2                    | 64.0  | 9.8     | 27.9               | 67.4    | 2.0   |

*Notes:* Canonical new-money issues, official-statement corpus 2005–25 (package v3), local governments only; dollar-weighted by effective par. Authorisation-mode shares are of determined dollars (93.7% of documents); security shares are of all dollars ('other' and unclassified omitted). Conduit issues without an accountable local government (11,750 documents, largely authority-class vehicles) are excluded here and appear in the menu matrix (Table A5).

**Reading.** Voter authorisation is the school-district norm and the exception everywhere else; the security mix mirrors it, with GO dominant for schools and revenue debt dominant for general-purpose and special-purpose governments.

**Table 3:** What each type of government borrows for

| Government type   | Project \$B | Largest purposes (share of the type's project dollars)                 |
|-------------------|-------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| School districts  | 356         | education 98%; general government 1%; parks / recreation / culture 0%  |
| Municipalities    | 386         | general government 36%; water / sewer / environment 17%; education 12% |
| Counties          | 120         | education 25%; transportation 18%; public safety / justice 16%         |
| Townships         | 31          | education 30%; water / sewer / environment 27%; general government 15% |
| Special districts | 85          | water / sewer / environment 33%; transportation 19%; utilities 19%     |

*Notes:* Same universe as Table 2; project dollars by the document's primary major function, excluding pure financing mechanics. Shares are of the type's own classified project dollars.

**Reading.** Each type of government is a different bundle of services, which is why the consent requirement cannot be one institution: the goods behind the ballot differ by who is asking.

**Fact 1: the consent requirement lands on different menus.** Why do the types differ so sharply? Not mainly because their statutes differ, but because their *services* differ. A school district builds classrooms: goods that cannot be charged to users, financeable only by taxes, hence by GO debt, which is precisely the instrument the law makes voters approve. A city runs water systems, car parks and utilities: chargeable services that support revenue bonds, leases and conduit borrowing, none of which faces an electorate. The referendum requirement is therefore not a single institution applied uniformly; it is a constraint whose bite depends on the **menu of exits** each government’s service mix provides. Where the menu is empty, the rule is the gatekeeper of provision. Where the menu is rich, the rule guards one instrument among many. This single observation generates the paper’s main predictions: the causal effect of authorisation should be large for menu-poor governments and absent for menu-rich ones (Section 8 confirms exactly this ordering), and political fights over the rule should concentrate on the menu-poor class (Section 9 shows they do). The full matrix of security by authorisation mode, per type and rule regime, is Appendix Table A5.

## 5.2 Which public goods face voters

Table 4 turns from who borrows to what the public is asked about, measured in the national corpus rather than in any state’s election registry, so the composition of a registry cannot skew it.

**Table 4:** Which public goods are voted on

| Purpose (major function)     | \$B | Voted share of \$ (%) | Issues |
|------------------------------|-----|-----------------------|--------|
| education                    | 434 | 62.7                  | 21,593 |
| general government           | 161 | 4.6                   | 3,114  |
| water / sewer / environment  | 115 | 22.3                  | 8,096  |
| transportation               | 79  | 26.5                  | 5,026  |
| parks / recreation / culture | 53  | 44.9                  | 2,780  |
| public safety / justice      | 37  | 30.2                  | 2,767  |
| economic development         | 36  | 21.0                  | 2,072  |
| utilities                    | 27  | 1.8                   | 589    |
| housing / community dev.     | 26  | 7.3                   | 776    |
| health / hospitals           | 9   | 45.8                  | 275    |

*Notes:* Same universe as Table 2: canonical new-money issues by local governments, by the document’s primary major function; voted share is of determined dollars within the function. Measured in the national corpus, so it is not affected by the composition of any state’s election registry. The finer 118-activity grain, including the near-zero-voted functions (hospitals, multifamily housing, power generation), is Appendix Table A6.

**Reading.** Voters are consulted about schools and civic infrastructure; the chargeable perimeter of the local state is financed without them.

The gradient is steep and it runs along chargeability. Education dollars are voted on nearly two-thirds of the time. The civic middle (parks, public safety, roads, water) is voted on a quarter to a half of the time. The chargeable perimeter is essentially never voted: utilities, housing and general-government office debt run at single digits. And the table understates the pattern, because it covers governments with an identifiable electorate; the conduit authorities that finance hospitals, multifamily housing and power projects have none, and at the fine activity grain those functions are voted on around 2% of the time (Appendix Table A6 lists them: \$197.7B of hospital projects, \$70.0B of multifamily housing, \$67.1B of power generation, essentially none of it balloted). What the consent requirement governs, in practice, is the class of goods that cannot be charged to users. That is worth stating plainly: the referendum is not how America governs local borrowing; it is

how America governs the non-chargeable core of local borrowing, which is why school districts, whose output is entirely non-chargeable, live under it almost alone.

### 5.3 The coalitions the same rule convenes

The written rule names a threshold, but a threshold is not a coalition. What a "50% requirement" demands depends entirely on who turns out, and turnout is a function of what kind of government is asking and when. Table 5 makes this concrete with the four states whose registries print vote counts.

**Table 5:** Absolute coalition sizes

| entity           | cycle | n    | votes cast p10/p50/p90   | yes-needed p10/p50/p90   |
|------------------|-------|------|--------------------------|--------------------------|
| school_district  | on    | 829  | 704 / 4,731 / 38,817     | 353 / 2,366 / 19,409     |
| school_district  | off   | 4006 | 270 / 1,293 / 7,133      | 136 / 647 / 3,567        |
| municipal        | on    | 431  | 1,101 / 15,217 / 181,750 | 551 / 7,609 / 90,876     |
| municipal        | off   | 1196 | 379 / 2,357 / 17,287     | 190 / 1,179 / 8,644      |
| special_district | on    | 106  | 2 / 161 / 2,247          | 2 / 81 / 1,124           |
| special_district | off   | 442  | 2 / 62 / 547             | 2 / 32 / 274             |
| county           | on    | 173  | 2,702 / 63,000 / 289,834 | 1,352 / 31,501 / 144,918 |
| county           | off   | 290  | 228 / 4,498 / 94,017     | 115 / 2,250 / 47,009     |

*Notes:* TX/WI/LA/NC counts; CDIAC reports percentages only; placeholder rows excluded.

**Reading.** The same statutory sentence convenes half a million voters in Harris County and two in a developer district.

The same Texas sentence that made Harris County assemble half a million yes-votes for its road programme authorised a developer's municipal utility district on **two votes of two cast**. This is not an anomaly; it is the institutional design. Special districts are drawn around handfuls of initial residents, often the developer's own employees, and their elections occur before anyone else lives there. School bonds, held off-cycle, are decided by hundreds of voters; city measures timed to presidential elections are decided by hundreds of thousands. The law's language is constant while the consenting public varies by five orders of magnitude. Two implications follow. Empirically, election timing and electorate composition are candidate moderators of the authorisation effect, which Section 8 tests. Substantively, a threshold rule delegates the size of the required coalition to whoever controls the timing and the boundaries of the electorate, an agenda power taken up in Section 9. (Registry rows with placeholder vote counts are excluded and documented; no estimate in the paper depends on them.)

### 5.4 Does the written rule govern behaviour?

Everything so far describes behaviour. This subsection connects it to the coded rules: comparing governments of the same type across state lines, is more of their borrowing voter-authorised where the statute makes the ballot mandatory? The test is a regression of the voted share of each government's borrowed dollars on the strict-rule indicator, within type, across the 90,604 local governments of the national panel, with the usual demographic and fiscal controls, region fixed effects, and standard errors clustered by state (Table 6). Because the question is "does the rule move behaviour within a class", the informative columns are the class-by-class ones; the pooled column mixes classes with completely different baselines and is shown only for completeness.

The rule shows up exactly where Fact 1 says it must. For school districts, moving from a non-strict to a strict state raises the voted share of borrowing by 69 percentage points, roughly

**Table 6:** The fifty-state first stage: strict rules and the voted share of borrowing

|                        | (1)<br>Pooled     | (2)<br>Schools       | (3)<br>Municipalities | (4)<br>Counties   | (5)<br>Special districts |
|------------------------|-------------------|----------------------|-----------------------|-------------------|--------------------------|
| Strict referendum rule | +0.099<br>(0.117) | +0.690***<br>(0.154) | +0.204***<br>(0.035)  | +0.108<br>(0.092) | +0.176***<br>(0.051)     |
| Controls               | Yes               | Yes                  | Yes                   | Yes               | Yes                      |
| Region fixed effects   | Yes               | Yes                  | Yes                   | Yes               | Yes                      |
| Entity-class dummies   | Yes               | —                    | —                     | —                 | —                        |
| Observations           | 13,928            | 6,857                | 3,176                 | 1,456             | 2,439                    |
| State clusters         | 48                | 41                   | 37                    | 43                | 37                       |

*Notes:* Dependent variable: the voted share of the government’s determined new-money dollars, 2005–25, measured from the official-statement corpus (package v3). Columns (2)–(5) estimate the class-specific coefficient on its own subsample. Townships are excluded (they carry a proxy municipal rule; adding them leaves the pooled coefficient at +0.090,  $t$  0.74). Entity panel (90,604 local governments; estimation samples below are the corpus-active units for each outcome). Weighted least squares; Census-region fixed effects; controls: ln population (ln total revenue for special districts), homeownership, share 65+, racial fractionalisation, ln median household income, county Democratic presidential share 2020. Standard errors clustered by state in parentheses. The strict-rule indicator is the PRELIMINARY pass-1 coding (verification pass in progress), so coefficients read as first-stage associations, not causal estimates. \*  $p < 0.1$ , \*\*  $p < 0.05$ , \*\*\*  $p < 0.01$ .

the difference between borrowing like a Texas district (most dollars voted) and an Ohio one (almost none). In raw shares, 68% of school dollars are voted under strict rules against 7% under non-strict ones (the full grid is Appendix Table A8). For municipalities the coefficient is a fifth the size, and for counties it is indistinguishable from zero, not because cities ignore the law but because so little of what they finance runs through the GO instrument the law regulates. Figure 1 maps the result: the voted share of local borrowing ranges from roughly 80% in Oklahoma to under 3% in New York, Pennsylvania, Tennessee and Kentucky, the states whose statutes require no local ballot.

One reversal is instructive rather than embarrassing. Townships show the opposite gradient (more voted borrowing under nominally non-strict rules), because the panel assigns them their state’s municipal rule, and New England towns in fact borrow by town-meeting vote in states coded non-strict for cities. The anomaly is the coding’s, not the world’s; a township-specific rule column is on the verification worklist. **[PENDING: rules pass-2.]**

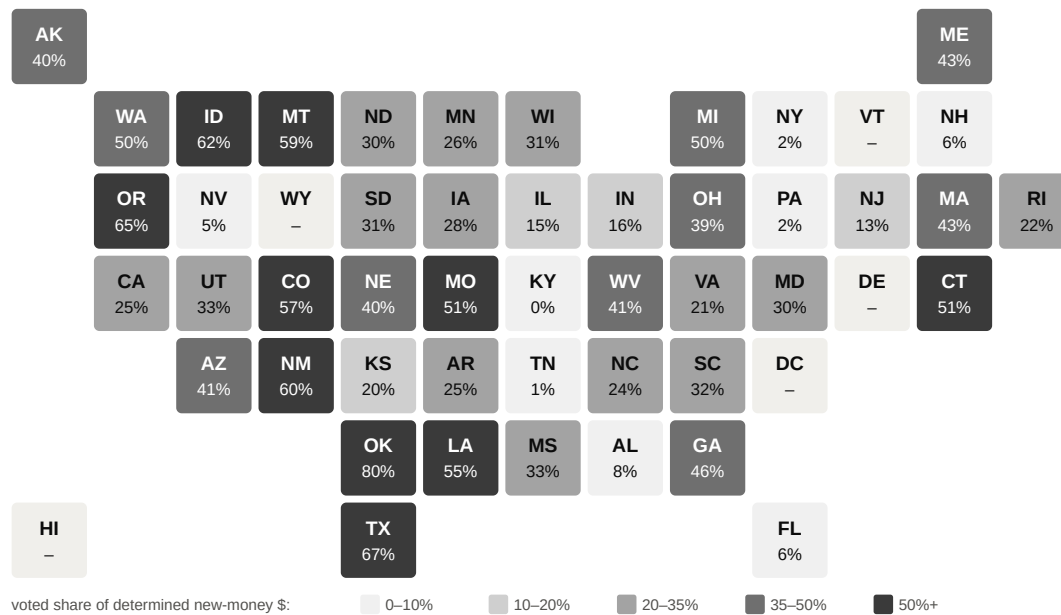
## 5.5 Where the rule binds, governments change instruments

If a strict rule makes the GO instrument costly to use, a government with alternatives should shift towards them, and a government without alternatives should simply ask more often. Table 7 tests the first half on the menu-rich class, general-purpose governments, in three steps: does the rule change *what security* they issue (columns 1 and 2), does it change *what kind of projects* their borrowing finances (columns 3 and 4), and does it change *how much they borrow at all* (columns 5 and 6)?

The answers are: yes, yes, and no. Cities and counties under strict rules carry a GO share of borrowing 28 percentage points lower than their counterparts in non-strict states; their borrowing also tilts away from non-chargeable projects (the schools-roads-parks class that only GO can finance) and towards chargeable ones, a shift of about 5 percentage points on the robust count basis (column 4; columns 3 and 4 measure the same outcome in dollars and in project-line counts, and the count basis is the one robust to a documented coverage imbalance, Appendix Table A4). But the extensive margin is quiet: whether a government borrows at all, and how much it raises

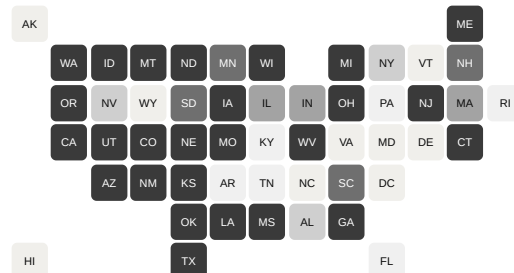
## The geography of consent

Share of local new-money debt (2005–25, \$-weighted) authorised by the voters, all local government classes

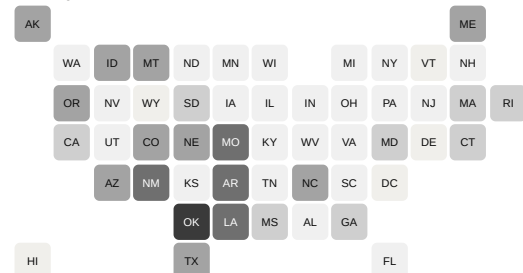


### By entity class (appendix)

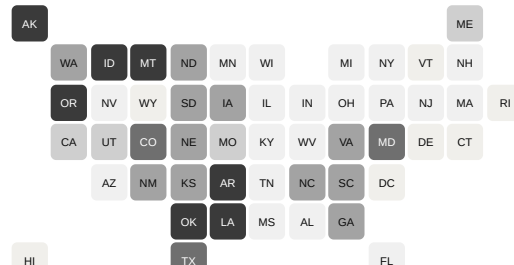
#### school districts



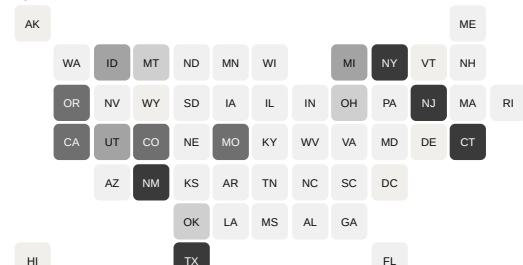
#### municipalities



#### counties



#### special districts



**Figure 1:** The geography of consent. Voted share of local new-money dollars by state, official-statement corpus 2005–25. States below the coverage gate (DC, DE, HI, VT, WY) are shown as no-data.



**Table 7:** Substitution away from the voted instrument, and the quiet extensive margin

|                        | (1)<br>GO<br>Pooled | (2)<br>GO<br>GP      | (3)<br>NC \$<br>GP | (4)<br>NC lines<br>GP | (5)<br>Any issue<br>All | (6)<br>In issued<br>All |
|------------------------|---------------------|----------------------|--------------------|-----------------------|-------------------------|-------------------------|
| Strict referendum rule | -0.155*<br>(0.086)  | -0.277***<br>(0.070) | -0.087<br>(0.054)  | -0.047**<br>(0.021)   | +0.015<br>(0.029)       | -0.232<br>(0.217)       |
| Controls               | Yes                 | Yes                  | Yes                | Yes                   | Yes                     | Yes                     |
| Region fixed effects   | Yes                 | Yes                  | Yes                | Yes                   | Yes                     | Yes                     |
| Observations           | 14,273              | 4,766                | 3,340              | 4,600                 | 56,541                  | 56,541                  |
| State clusters         | 48                  | 46                   | 46                 | 46                    | 48                      | 48                      |

*Notes:* Dependent variables: (1)–(2) GO = share of new-money dollars issued as general-obligation (GO) security; (3) share of classified project dollars in non-chargeable functions (services that cannot be billed to users); (4) the same composition measured in classified use-of-proceeds line counts, the basis robust to the coverage imbalance documented in Appendix Table A4 and therefore the estimate the text cites; (5) Any issue = linear probability of any corpus new-money issue 2005–25; (6) In issued = log survey long-term debt issued per capita 2005–23 (Government Finance Database). GP = general-purpose governments (municipalities and counties); schools are near-degenerate for the non-chargeable outcome and dilute the pooled composition rows. Entity panel (90,604 local governments; estimation samples below are the corpus-active units for each outcome). Weighted least squares; Census-region fixed effects; controls: ln population (ln total revenue for special districts), homeownership, share 65+, racial fractionalisation, ln median household income, county Democratic presidential share 2020. Standard errors clustered by state in parentheses. The strict-rule indicator is the PRELIMINARY pass-1 coding (verification pass in progress), so coefficients read as first-stage associations, not causal estimates. \*  $p < 0.1$ , \*\*  $p < 0.05$ , \*\*\*  $p < 0.01$ .

in total, is unrelated to the rule. The requirement redirects borrowing across instruments and purposes; it does not stop borrowing. That is the cross-sectional face of the causal finding in the next section, that refusal delays provision rather than preventing it. Institutional and demographic interactions (tax-and-expenditure limits, homeownership, partisanship) are uniformly weak and sit in Appendix Table A9.

## 6 · What authorisation causes: evidence from close elections

**Whose elections are these?** The 11,889 GO measures at statutory thresholds are dominated by the menu-poor sector: 65% school districts, 18% municipalities, 13% special districts and 4% counties, across Texas and Wisconsin (50% threshold), California (55% for schools, 66.7% otherwise), Louisiana and North Carolina. The average effects below are therefore mostly school-district effects, and Section 8 splits every result by type; the split is not a robustness exercise but, per Fact 1, the theory’s central prediction.

**The design, in plain terms.** A district that wins its bond election with 50.4% and one that loses with 49.6% are the same kind of place on the same day; the only difference is which side of the statutory line the count landed. Comparing many near-winners with near-losers therefore isolates what authorisation itself causes. Table 8 verifies the premise: none of seven pre-vote characteristics (prior borrowing, size, income, homeownership, age structure, prior failed measures) differs across the cutoff. The one wrinkle, visible in Figure 2, is that slightly more measures sit just above the line than just below it, concentrated in Texas: governments time proposals they expect to win, a fact documented since Cellini, Ferreira and Rothstein (2010) that is itself evidence for the agenda story of Section 9. Estimates that discard the contested sliver around the cutoff are, if anything, larger (Appendix Table A1).

**Authorisation raises issuance by about eleven percentage points.** Passed measures

**Table 8:** Covariate continuity at the authorisation threshold

| Outcome                                    | RBC                          | robust $p$ | Conv.  | $h$      | Eff. $N$ (L/R) |
|--------------------------------------------|------------------------------|------------|--------|----------|----------------|
| Any new-money issue, year $t-2$            | +0.030<br>[-0.028, +0.089]   | 0.314      | +0.007 | $\pm 10$ | 1,596/2,743    |
| Any new-money issue, year $t-1$            | +0.021<br>[-0.036, +0.079]   | 0.468      | +0.022 | $\pm 10$ | 1,596/2,743    |
| $\ln(1+\text{LTD issued p.c., } t-3..t-1)$ | +0.530<br>[-0.256, +1.315]   | 0.186      | +0.412 | $\pm 10$ | 1,495/2,553    |
| $\ln$ population                           | +0.320<br>[-0.521, +1.160]   | 0.456      | +0.142 | $\pm 10$ | 252/497        |
| $\ln$ enrolment (schools)                  | -0.035<br>[-0.343, +0.272]   | 0.822      | -0.001 | $\pm 10$ | 1,285/2,130    |
| Homeownership share                        | -0.005<br>[-0.028, +0.017]   | 0.641      | +0.001 | $\pm 10$ | 1,596/2,742    |
| $\ln$ median household income              | +0.065**<br>[+0.004, +0.126] | 0.038      | +0.040 | $\pm 10$ | 1,596/2,742    |
| Share aged 65+                             | -0.004<br>[-0.014, +0.005]   | 0.370      | -0.002 | $\pm 10$ | 1,596/2,742    |
| Prior failed measure $\leq 4y$             | -0.018<br>[-0.104, +0.069]   | 0.689      | -0.016 | $\pm 10$ | 1,596/2,743    |

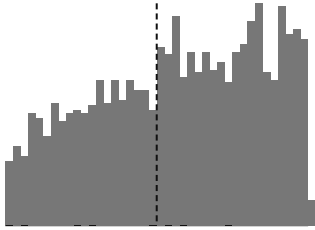
*Notes:* Frame:  $rd\_sample \cap GO$  measures, corpus package v3 (frozen). RBC = robust bias-corrected local-quadratic estimate at  $h$  with robust CI (Calonico–Cattaneo–Titiunik,  $\rho = 1$ ); conventional = local-linear, triangular kernel. Bandwidth fixed at  $\pm 10pp$  per the reconciliation in Appendix Table A1 (MSE-optimal row and bandwidth-sensitivity curve there). \*  $p < 0.1$ , \*\*  $p < 0.05$ , \*\*\*  $p < 0.01$  (robust). Pre-vote covariates; ACS at place grain for municipalities, district grain for schools, county otherwise.

**Reading.** No pre-vote covariate jumps at the cutoff; the two lagged-issuance indicators and lagged borrowing are smooth, so barely-passed and barely-failed governments were on the same path before the vote.

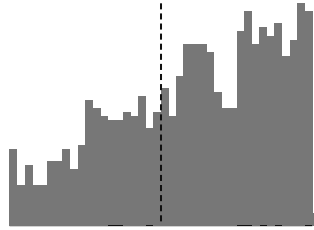
### Density of the vote margin, by state

0.5pp bins within  $\pm 10$ pp of the threshold; the Texas discreteness is visible at the smallest electorates

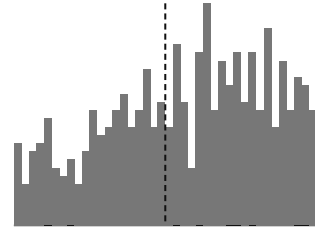
Texas (n=2,290)



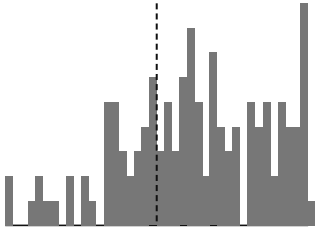
California (n=1,285)



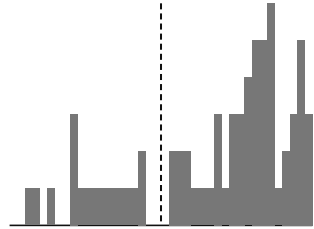
Wisconsin (n=566)



Louisiana (n=129)



North Carolina (n=69)



McCrary log-density: pooled +0.140 (z 2.58); TX +0.206 (z 2.71); all other states n.s. Donut estimates (Table A1) are stable to l

**Figure 2:** Density of the vote margin by state. Histograms of the running variable within  $\pm 10$ pp; the discreteness of small Texas electorates is visible. McCrary log-density discontinuity: pooled +0.24 (z 4.6) at  $h = 5$ pp, +0.14 (z 2.6) over this full  $\pm 10$ pp window; Texas +0.21 (z 2.7); all other states approximately zero.

are followed by borrowing far more often than failed ones (36% against 15% within six years), but most of that gap is selection: popular projects both pass and proceed. At the cutoff, where selection is removed, authorisation raises the probability of GO issuance by 11 percentage points (Table 9, Figure 3). The estimate replicates in every adequately powered state, across three different thresholds, at very similar magnitudes (Appendix Table A2); placebo thresholds show nothing (Appendix Table A3). Borrowed amounts roughly double at the cutoff, and, decisively for the worry that refused governments simply borrow in unrecorded ways, the same doubling appears in Census survey data, which capture the bank loans and private placements no official statement records.

**Table 9:** The effect of authorisation on borrowing and building

| Outcome                                               | RBC                           | robust $p$ | Conv.  | $h$      | Eff. $N$ (L/R) |
|-------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------|------------|--------|----------|----------------|
| Any GO issuance $\leq 6y$                             | +0.110**<br>[+0.016, +0.204]  | 0.022      | +0.146 | $\pm 10$ | 1,596/2,743    |
| Any issuance $\leq 6y$                                | +0.116**<br>[+0.023, +0.209]  | 0.014      | +0.144 | $\pm 10$ | 1,596/2,743    |
| $\ln(1+\text{new-money par p.c.})$                    | +0.937**<br>[+0.057, +1.818]  | 0.037      | +0.918 | $\pm 10$ | 1,537/2,627    |
| $\ln(1+\text{LTD issued p.c.})$ , Census survey       | +0.878**<br>[+0.146, +1.610]  | 0.019      | +0.827 | $\pm 10$ | 1,238/2,128    |
| Same-purpose continuation $\leq 6y$                   | +0.052<br>[-0.047, +0.152]    | 0.302      | +0.073 | $\pm 10$ | 1,398/2,456    |
| Voter-mode first issuance $\leq 6y$                   | +0.184***<br>[+0.089, +0.278] | <0.001     | +0.199 | $\pm 10$ | 1,596/2,743    |
| No issuance $\leq 6y$                                 | -0.116**<br>[-0.209, -0.023]  | 0.014      | -0.144 | $\pm 10$ | 1,596/2,743    |
| Capital outlay p.c. (pay-go bound; schools, post-pre) | +0.464**<br>[+0.090, +0.837]  | 0.015      | +0.377 | $\pm 10$ | 996/1,621      |

*Notes:* Frame:  $\text{rd\_sample} \cap \text{GO measures}$ , corpus package v3 (frozen). RBC = robust bias-corrected local-quadratic estimate at  $h$  with robust CI (Calonico–Cattaneo–Titiunik,  $\rho = 1$ ); conventional = local-linear, triangular kernel. Bandwidth fixed at  $\pm 10\text{pp}$  per the reconciliation in Appendix Table A1 (MSE-optimal row and bandwidth-sensitivity curve there). \*  $p < 0.1$ , \*\*  $p < 0.05$ , \*\*\*  $p < 0.01$  (robust). Survey row: GFD/IUF, EMMA-independent (survivorship check). Continuation: ballot purpose matched to use-of-proceeds functions; bridge precision 80.0% (blind audit). Pay-go row: full-window cohort (votes to  $\sim 2017\text{--}18$ , outlay to FY2023).

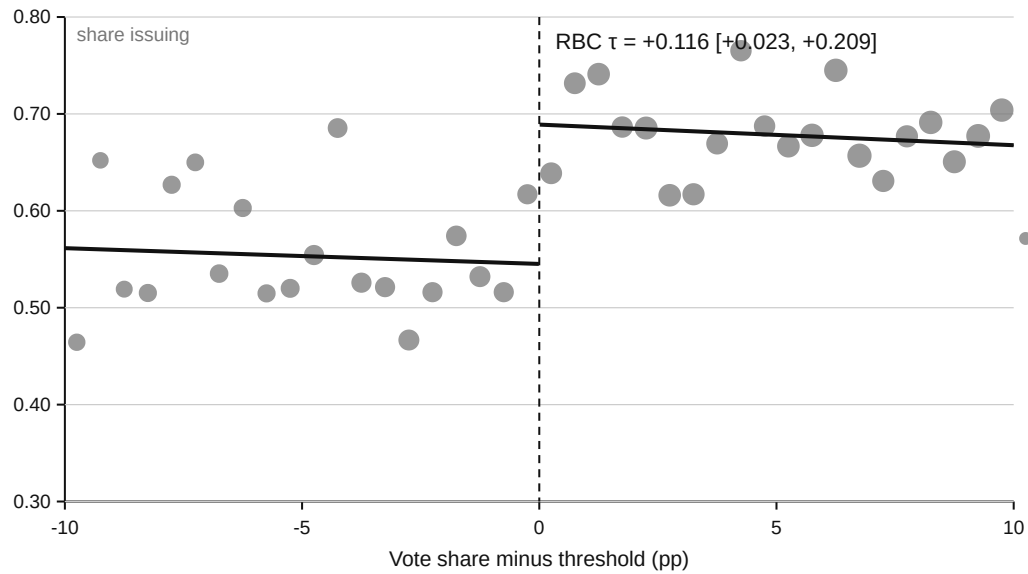
**Reading.** A narrow authorisation raises six-year GO issuance by eleven points (robust), roughly doubles per-capita borrowing in disclosure and survey data alike, raises same-purpose project delivery, and moves building nearly one-for-one with borrowing: refusal is not offset by pay-go construction.

**Why a six-year window?** Passed authorisations are drawn down in series: the median barely-passed issuer reaches the market within four months of the vote, but districts routinely issue against an authorisation for years (Texas districts draw on decade-old ones). A six-year window is long enough to capture the drawdown and, more importantly, to give the refused side time to catch up through re-votes, which Section 7 shows is the main thing they do; a shorter window would overstate the effect by counting delay as denial. The choice is not load-bearing: the effect is visible at every horizon from one to six years (Appendix Figure A1), and the event study in Figure 4 shows it arrives immediately, in the vote year itself, with no differences before the vote and a persistent level shift after.

**Delay, and a wedge that does not close.** Figure 5 accumulates issuance on both sides

### Issuance at the authorisation threshold

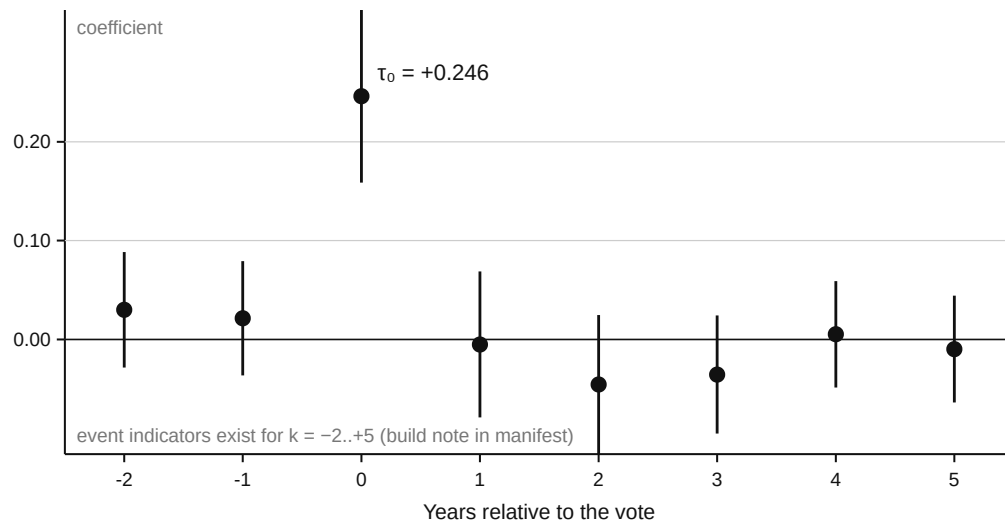
Share with any issuance within six years; 0.5pp bins sized by n; local-linear fits



**Figure 3:** Issuance at the authorisation threshold. Share of measures followed by any issuance within six years, in 0.5pp bins of the running variable sized by cell count, with local-linear fits and the RBC estimate annotated.

### Event study: issuance by year relative to the vote

RBC coefficients with robust 95% CIs; outcome = any new-money issue in relative year k

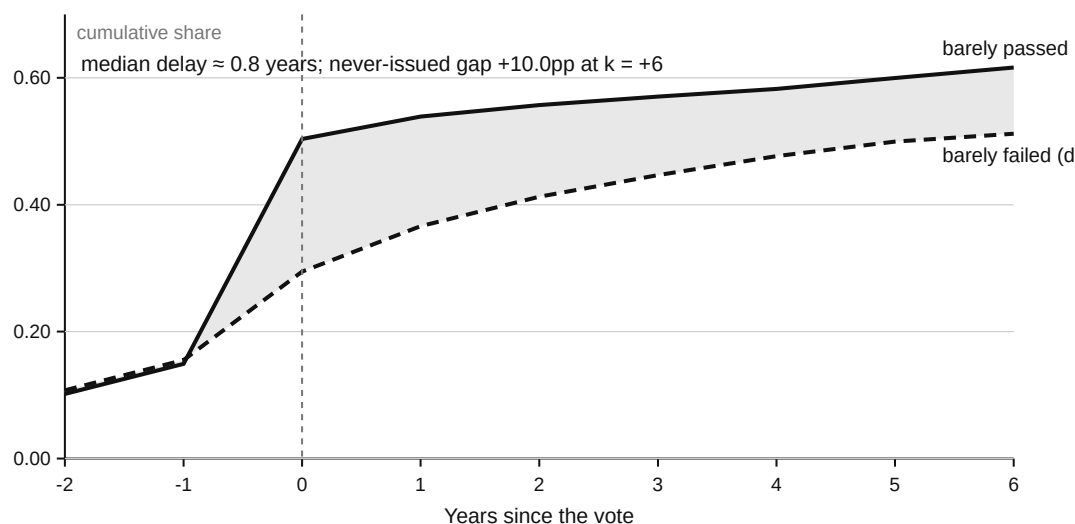


**Figure 4:** Event study. Coefficient on issuance in each year relative to the vote, with robust confidence intervals.

of the cutoff. The refused side starts a year late (median first issue 1.15 years against 0.33) and, despite six years of re-votes and catch-up, never reaches the authorised side's level: by year six, half of barely-refused governments have still issued nothing, against 40% of barely-authorised ones. That ten-point wedge is the durable cost of refusal. The full battery of robustness checks (donuts, clustering variants, bounds for crosswalk selection, randomisation inference, bandwidths) is Appendix Table A1; one final row there deserves mention in text, the **pay-go bound**: rerunning the whole design with Census capital spending as the outcome shows construction falling with borrowing at a ratio near one. Refused districts do not quietly build anyway out of savings; refusal delays the building itself.

### The cumulative wedge

Cumulative share with any new-money issue since  $k = -2$ ,  $|\text{margin}| \leq 5$ ; shaded area = the wedge



**Figure 5:** The cumulative wedge. Cumulative any-issuance for barely-passed (solid) and barely-failed (dashed) measures; the shaded area is the wedge; median market-entry times annotated.

## 7 · What happens when a measure fails

The theory's distinctive claim is that a coalition requirement prices delay, not denial. This section follows every refused measure forward. Table 10 collects the accounting; the text walks through it.

**Refusal is a pause, not a verdict.** Of 2,680 failed GO measures, well over half return to the ballot within four years, most at the very next election, and when they return they usually win. Districts do not come back chastened: the median returning measure asks for exactly the original amount, and four-fifths of the original purposes survive into the re-submission. Adding up the fates of 100 barely-refused measures: 54 are re-approved by voters within four years, 13 more have returned and await a verdict, 9 issue on authorisations their voters had approved earlier (banked authority, not evasion), only 5 borrow through a board or statutory channel, and 18 are extinguished within the horizon. The transition matrix beneath Table 10 makes the same point

**Table 10:** The response margin: what refusal buys

| Quantity                                                                                                        | Value                     |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------|
| <i>Panel A: the fate of 100 marginal refusals (2005–19 cohort, <math> m  \leq 5</math>, <math>n=422</math>)</i> |                           |
| Re-approved by voters $\leq 4y$                                                                                 | 54.3                      |
| Returned, not yet converted                                                                                     | 13.3                      |
| Issued via board or statutory channel                                                                           | 5.2                       |
| Issued on pre-existing voter authority                                                                          | 9.0                       |
| Extinguished within horizon                                                                                     | 18.2                      |
| <i>First post-vote authoriser (<math> m  \leq 5</math>): barely-passed vs barely-failed</i>                     |                           |
| barely-PASSED: voter 48.4%, board 7.9%, none 43.1%                                                              |                           |
| barely-FAILED: voter 36.7%, board 8.6%, none 54.2%                                                              |                           |
| <i>Panel B: re-submission (2,680 failed GO measures)</i>                                                        |                           |
| Hazard, years 1/2/3/4 (%)                                                                                       | 26.7 / 22.8 / 15.8 / 12.4 |
| Cumulative return within 4y (%)                                                                                 | 58.2                      |
| Median time to return (years)                                                                                   | 1.02                      |
| Returns that pass (%)                                                                                           | 61.9                      |
| Median amount ratio, return/original                                                                            | 1.000                     |
| Purpose categories retained on return (%)                                                                       | 78.2                      |

*Notes:* Fates are mutually exclusive per 100 barely-refused measures; issuance on pre-existing voter authority draws on authorisations banked before the refused measure and is not evidence of evading it. Panel B: full failed sample; amounts where registries print them ( $n=1,354$ ). Retention from the audited purpose bridge (precision 80.0%).

**Reading.** Refusal is a pause: most marginal refusals are re-approved at the next election at the same ask, fewer than one in five extinguish, and the board channel is a floor rather than the treatment margin.

from the other side: what the cutoff moves is voter-authorized issuance against no issuance at all, while board-channel issuance sits near 8% on both sides of the line. For the menu-poor sector, the board channel is a floor, not an escape route.

**The project itself usually survives.** Matching each measure’s stated purpose to the classified purposes of the government’s subsequent bonds, a third of narrowly refused projects are financed within six years anyway, against 45% of narrowly passed ones, arriving over a year later. Refusal costs time and forces a second campaign; it only rarely kills the school extension. And the pay-go bound of Section 6 closes the remaining loophole: the gap is not being filled by debt-free construction.

**One exception: supermajority near-misses bank consent that stalls.** Within California, measures that won a majority but missed the supermajority threshold behave differently. They re-submit far more often than decisive failures and convert to passage at four times the rate, yet the authorisations they eventually win sit undrawn: median time from re-vote to first issue is over six years, against under three for ordinary passes, and their issuance deficit widens rather than closes between years six and eight (Appendix Table A10). Where the bar is a supermajority, even re-assembled consent does not become borrowing on the study horizon. A candidate mechanism, statutory tax-rate caps metering the drawdown, could be neither supported nor excluded on the available cells (Appendix Table A11); the fact stands documented and unexplained.

## 8 · Where the requirement binds: exits and electorates

Everything above averages over the frame. The theory says the average is the wrong object: the effect should live where the menu is empty and die where it is rich, and it should depend on who the convened electorate is. Both predictions hold, and they are the paper’s core results as much as the average is.

**By type of government: the fork.** Table 11 re-estimates the design within each class and sets the estimates against each class’s national menu from Section 5. School districts, the menu-poor class, show the binding effect and the highest re-submission rate: for them, the ballot is the gate. General-purpose governments, the menu-rich class, show no discontinuity at all and rarely re-submit: for them, refusal is nearly costless, because the same project can usually be financed through an instrument that needs no election. Special districts sit between, and their GO-specific jump shrinks once all instruments are counted, direct evidence of the rerouting that Table 7 showed in cross-section. The ordering across the three classes, binding, intermediate, absent, is exactly the menu ordering of Table 2, estimated from entirely different data.

**Table 11:** Exits and the binding of refusal: the fork against the menu

| Outcome                                                      | RBC                          | robust $p$ | Conv.  | $h$      | Eff. $N$ (L/R) |
|--------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------|------------|--------|----------|----------------|
| Schools, GO issuance                                         | +0.123**<br>[+0.018, +0.228] | 0.022      | +0.147 | $\pm 10$ | 1,289/2,144    |
| Any issuance                                                 | +0.132**<br>[+0.027, +0.236] | 0.013      | +0.150 | $\pm 10$ | 1,289/2,144    |
| menu: non-voted \$ share 36.6%; failures re-submitting 0.592 |                              |            |        |          |                |
| General-purpose, GO issuance                                 | -0.024<br>[-0.251, +0.203]   | 0.837      | +0.073 | $\pm 10$ | 252/498        |
| Any issuance                                                 | -0.028<br>[-0.249, +0.192]   | 0.800      | +0.045 | $\pm 10$ | 252/498        |
| menu: non-voted \$ share 86.1%; failures re-submitting 0.253 |                              |            |        |          |                |
| Utilities (special districts), GO issuance                   | +0.500*<br>[-0.015, +1.016]  | 0.057      | +0.463 | $\pm 10$ | 55/101         |
| Any issuance                                                 | +0.359<br>[-0.169, +0.888]   | 0.182      | +0.362 | $\pm 10$ | 55/101         |
| menu: non-voted \$ share 73.8%; failures re-submitting 0.426 |                              |            |        |          |                |

*Notes:* Frame:  $rd\_sample \cap GO$  measures, corpus package v3 (frozen). RBC = robust bias-corrected local-quadratic estimate at  $h$  with robust CI (Calonico–Cattaneo–Titiunik,  $\rho = 1$ ); conventional = local-linear, triangular kernel. Bandwidth fixed at  $\pm 10pp$  per the reconciliation in Appendix Table A1 (MSE-optimal row and bandwidth-sensitivity curve there). \*  $p < 0.1$ , \*\*  $p < 0.05$ , \*\*\*  $p < 0.01$  (robust). Menu shares from the national corpus (independent of the RD frame). Utilities cells are small; the ordering, not the magnitude, is the cited object.

**Reading.** Refusal binds exactly where the exit menu is poorest: schools show the discontinuity and the highest re-submission; general-purpose governments, with the richest menu, show none.

**By electorate: the stable propertied public.** Splitting the frame at its median on electorate characteristics (Table 12), the effect is carried by places with high homeownership, older populations, and on-cycle elections, and it is absent in renter-heavy, diverse, off-cycle places. It is ownership, not affluence: the income split is flat. And it is institutional, not partisan: neither city partisanship nor mayoral party moderates anything. A natural first guess, that heterogeneity makes coalitions harder to assemble and so weakens the effect, fails on its own sign; the profile



instead favours a **stable propertied public** account, in which authorisation binds where the consenting public is durable enough for its refusals to stay refused and its approvals to licence years of drawdown. This reading was adopted after seeing the pattern and is flagged as such. The incidence is regressive in one documented sense: in California, the measures that win majorities but die under supermajority thresholds come disproportionately from poorer, mid-composition districts (Appendix Table A12).

**Table 12:** Where the requirement binds: splits at within-frame medians

| Outcome                                           | RBC                           | robust $p$ | Conv.  | $h$      | Eff. $N$ (L/R) |
|---------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------|------------|--------|----------|----------------|
| Homeownership: below median                       | -0.065<br>[-0.232, +0.103]    | 0.451      | +0.056 | $\pm 10$ | 432/863        |
| Homeownership: above median                       | +0.196**<br>[+0.044, +0.348]  | 0.011      | +0.182 | $\pm 10$ | 575/861        |
| difference (above–below)                          | +0.261**                      | 0.024      |        |          |                |
| Share 65+: below median                           | +0.043<br>[-0.129, +0.215]    | 0.622      | +0.036 | $\pm 10$ | 408/781        |
| Share 65+: above median                           | +0.097<br>[-0.055, +0.249]    | 0.210      | +0.194 | $\pm 10$ | 599/943        |
| difference (above–below)                          | +0.054                        | 0.646      |        |          |                |
| Racial-ethnic homogeneity (1–frac.): below median | -0.092<br>[-0.270, +0.086]    | 0.311      | -0.018 | $\pm 10$ | 415/818        |
| Racial-ethnic homogeneity (1–frac.): above median | +0.203***<br>[+0.059, +0.348] | 0.006      | +0.232 | $\pm 10$ | 592/906        |
| difference (above–below)                          | +0.295**                      | 0.012      |        |          |                |
| Median household income: below median             | +0.030<br>[-0.127, +0.187]    | 0.711      | +0.129 | $\pm 10$ | 482/802        |
| Median household income: above median             | +0.123<br>[-0.041, +0.288]    | 0.142      | +0.122 | $\pm 10$ | 525/922        |
| difference (above–below)                          | +0.094                        | 0.420      |        |          |                |
| On-cycle (November, even year)                    | +0.192**<br>[+0.024, +0.361]  | 0.025      | +0.252 | $\pm 10$ | 476/1,005      |
| Off-cycle                                         | +0.072<br>[-0.039, +0.182]    | 0.205      | +0.099 | $\pm 10$ | 1,120/1,738    |
| difference (on–off)                               | +0.121                        | 0.240      |        |          |                |

*Notes:* Frame:  $rd\_sample \cap GO$  measures, corpus package v3 (frozen). RBC = robust bias-corrected local-quadratic estimate at  $h$  with robust CI (Calonico–Cattaneo–Titiunik,  $\rho = 1$ ); conventional = local-linear, triangular kernel. Bandwidth fixed at  $\pm 10pp$  per the reconciliation in Appendix Table A1 (MSE-optimal row and bandwidth-sensitivity curve there). \*  $p < 0.1$ , \*\*  $p < 0.05$ , \*\*\*  $p < 0.01$  (robust). Demographic splits run on the 6,255 proper-grain measures (place grain for municipalities, district grain for schools); special districts excluded pending sub-county demographics. Partisanship (precinct-built 577-city panel, all subgroups n.s.) in Appendix Table A-P1.

**Reading.** The effect concentrates where the consenting public is propertied, older, homogeneous and consulted on-cycle; it is ownership, not income, and institutional, not partisan.

## 9 · The agenda margin and the politics of the rule

**Rules discipline what is asked before any vote is cast.** Under California’s 55% bar, school districts bring far fewer, larger, better timed proposals than under Texas’s 50% bar (Table 13): 9 against 20 proposals per hundred districts per year, at median asks of \$39M against \$15M, mostly on-cycle against mostly off-cycle. Pass rates barely differ between the 50% and 55% regimes and collapse only at two-thirds: a moderate bar is absorbed by the agenda, an extreme bar defeats even what careful selection permits. Texas’s 2019 unbundling reform closes the loop within one state: when stadiums and performing-arts facilities had to be separate propositions, proposition counts jumped within two cycles. Bundling, timing and ask size are choices the rule shapes, and the excess of near-winners at the cutoff (Section 6) is the same behaviour seen from below.

**Table 13:** The agenda margin by regime

| state (thr) | #districts | proposals/yr | per 100 districts/yr | median amount | on-cycle share |
|-------------|------------|--------------|----------------------|---------------|----------------|
| CA (55)     | 1065       | 93.5         | 8.78                 | \$39,000,000  | 62.7%          |
| TX (50)     | 1093       | 219.2        | 20.05                | \$15,000,000  | 14.1%          |
| WI (50)     | 440        | 48.4         | 11.00                | \$12,600,000  | 30.5%          |
| MN (50)     | 392        | 0            | —                    | —             | —              |

*Notes:* School GO proposal behaviour 2005–25; MN empty by classification (a data fact). Passage-rate and TX-2019 unbundling panels in the CSV companion (A4b, A4c).

**Reading.** Under the higher bar districts propose half as often, at 2.6 times the size, four times more on-cycle; pass rates barely move until two-thirds.

**At fixed voter support, the rule alone moves outcomes.** In the band between 50% and 55%, the identical election result authorises a Texan or Wisconsin district and refuses a Californian one. Comparing issuance across that band yields an estimate of the rule’s effect at fixed support, +11.5 points (SE 4.8), indistinguishable from the RD estimate obtained from an entirely different comparison. This out-of-design agreement is the strongest single check in the paper.

**The polity fights over the rule exactly where the menu is empty.** Since 1990, nearly every attempt to lower a local borrowing threshold has targeted schools: California’s Propositions 170, 26 and 39 (the last passing 53 to 47, schools only, behind a \$30M campaign), Washington’s stalled school-bond bills, Idaho’s dozen failed attempts. The one recent non-school attempt, California’s Proposition 5 (2024), failed. Where exits exist, nobody spends thirty million dollars to lower the bar; where they do not, the rule is worth fighting over, which is precisely Fact 1 read as politics. (The reform record is compiled from secondary sources, marked secondary-unverified pending primary checks, and cited as evidence on reform politics only. The cleanest reform event, Proposition 39 itself, does not yet yield a credible state-level causal estimate, for data reasons documented in the appendix honesty record; the causal weight of the paper rests on the within-state designs of Section 6.)

## Appendix tables and figures

**Table A1:** Specification battery for the main estimate

| Check                                 | Result                                                                                                                                                        |
|---------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Donut $ m  > 0.5\text{pp}$            | RBC +0.208 [+0.087, +0.329]; conv. +0.195; N 1,502/2,622                                                                                                      |
| Donut $ m  > 1.0\text{pp}$            | RBC +0.188 [+0.033, +0.343]; conv. +0.186; N 1,409/2,498                                                                                                      |
| Donut $ m  > 2.0\text{pp}$            | RBC +0.249 [-0.024, +0.521]; conv. +0.199; N 1,199/2,240                                                                                                      |
| Excluding Louisiana                   | RBC +0.133 [+0.037, +0.229]; conv. +0.162                                                                                                                     |
| Cluster by unit (2,480)               | conv. +0.146, SE 0.036, $z$ 4.11                                                                                                                              |
| Cluster by county (650)               | conv. +0.146, SE 0.042, $z$ 3.47                                                                                                                              |
| Lee bounds (crosswalk trim 2.52%)     | [+0.138, +0.163]                                                                                                                                              |
| Randomisation inference, $ m  \leq 2$ | diff. +0.142, $p < 0.0002$ (5,000 permutations)                                                                                                               |
| IK MSE-optimal bandwidth              | $h = 1.81\text{pp}$ ; $\tau = -0.001$ (SE 0.075): slope-dominated on two points of support; the design-based tests above at the same window reject decisively |
| Alternative horizons 1–6y             | Appendix Figure A1a (coefficients rise to the 6y wedge)                                                                                                       |
| Bandwidth sensitivity $h \in [3, 15]$ | Appendix Figure A1b (stable from $h \geq 6$ )                                                                                                                 |

*Notes:* Frame:  $\text{rd\_sample} \cap \text{GO}$  measures, corpus package v3 (frozen). RBC = robust bias-corrected local-quadratic estimate at  $h$  with robust CI (Calonico–Cattaneo–Titiunik,  $\rho = 1$ ); conventional = local-linear, triangular kernel. Bandwidth fixed at  $\pm 10\text{pp}$  per the reconciliation in Appendix Table A1 (MSE-optimal row and bandwidth-sensitivity curve there). \*  $p < 0.1$ , \*\*  $p < 0.05$ , \*\*\*  $p < 0.01$  (robust). Clustered, Lee, randomisation and IK rows from the committed polish battery (POLISH\_RESULTS.md).

**Reading.** The estimate survives every design-based and inference variant; the one non-rejecting diagnostic (the MSE-optimal local fit) is a power statement, reconciled in the note.

**Table A2:** The main estimate, state by state

| Outcome                                    | RBC                          | robust $p$ | Conv.  | $h$      | Eff. $N$ (L/R) |
|--------------------------------------------|------------------------------|------------|--------|----------|----------------|
| Texas (50%)                                | +0.134**<br>[+0.011, +0.256] | 0.032      | +0.141 | $\pm 10$ | 892/1,398      |
| California schools (55%)                   | +0.059<br>[-0.154, +0.271]   | 0.589      | +0.105 | $\pm 10$ | 261/692        |
| California non-school (66.7%) (small cell) | +0.295**<br>[+0.048, +0.541] | 0.019      | +0.260 | $\pm 10$ | 166/164        |
| Wisconsin (50%)                            | +0.167*<br>[-0.021, +0.356]  | 0.082      | +0.212 | $\pm 10$ | 221/345        |
| Louisiana (50%) (small; parish-fold grain) | -0.396*<br>[-0.796, +0.004]  | 0.052      | -0.276 | $\pm 10$ | 40/89          |
| North Carolina (50%) (small cell)          | -0.209<br>[-1.353, +0.934]   | 0.720      | +0.216 | $\pm 10$ | 16/53          |

*Notes:* Frame:  $rd\_sample \cap GO$  measures, corpus package v3 (frozen). RBC = robust bias-corrected local-quadratic estimate at  $h$  with robust CI (Calonico–Cattaneo–Titiunik,  $\rho = 1$ ); conventional = local-linear, triangular kernel. Bandwidth fixed at  $\pm 10pp$  per the reconciliation in Appendix Table A1 (MSE-optimal row and bandwidth-sensitivity curve there). \*  $p < 0.1$ , \*\*  $p < 0.05$ , \*\*\*  $p < 0.01$  (robust). Louisiana outcomes fold to the parish; the pooled estimate excluding Louisiana appears in Appendix Table A1.

**Reading.** Three adequately powered states, three different thresholds, one answer; the small cells are directionally consistent except fold-grain Louisiana.

**Table A3:** Placebo thresholds: no jump where the law draws no line

| Outcome                                               | RBC                         | robust $p$ | Conv.  | $h$      | Eff. $N$ (L/R) |
|-------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------|------------|--------|----------|----------------|
| 50%-regime states, pseudo-cutoff 45 (both sides fail) | +0.143*<br>[-0.004, +0.290] | 0.057      | +0.012 | $\pm 10$ | 786/687        |
| 50%-regime states, pseudo-cutoff 60 (both sides pass) | -0.045<br>[-0.129, +0.039]  | 0.296      | -0.014 | $\pm 10$ | 1,874/1,852    |
| CA 66.7% regime, pseudo-cutoff 60 (both sides fail)   | -0.068<br>[-0.394, +0.259]  | 0.685      | -0.007 | $\pm 10$ | 69/126         |
| CA 55% regime, pseudo-cutoff 60 (both sides pass)     | -0.039<br>[-0.264, +0.187]  | 0.736      | +0.052 | $\pm 10$ | 280/764        |

*Notes:* Frame:  $rd\_sample \cap GO$  measures, corpus package v3 (frozen). RBC = robust bias-corrected local-quadratic estimate at  $h$  with robust CI (Calonico–Cattaneo–Titiunik,  $\rho = 1$ ); conventional = local-linear, triangular kernel. Bandwidth fixed at  $\pm 10pp$  per the reconciliation in Appendix Table A1 (MSE-optimal row and bandwidth-sensitivity curve there). \*  $p < 0.1$ , \*\*  $p < 0.05$ , \*\*\*  $p < 0.01$  (robust). Pseudo-cutoffs estimated within samples where both sides share the same legal outcome.

**Reading.** Issuance is smooth through vote shares at which nothing legal changes; the discontinuity appears only at the statutory threshold.

**Table A4:** Classified-line coverage by regime (nc-share selection check)

| sample                        | regime      | units  | unit coverage | \$ coverage |
|-------------------------------|-------------|--------|---------------|-------------|
| all classes                   | strict      | 12,838 | 63.5%         | 82.7%       |
| all classes                   | non-strict  | 2,040  | 77.6%         | 83.9%       |
| all classes                   | not codable | 3,450  | 48.3%         | 80.1%       |
| general-purpose (muni+county) | strict      | 3,776  | 68.7%         | 90.3%       |
| general-purpose (muni+county) | non-strict  | 1,006  | 75.1%         | 84.9%       |
| general-purpose (muni+county) | not codable | 1,926  | 60.9%         | 92.5%       |
| schools                       | strict      | 6,763  | 66.7%         | 80.7%       |
| schools                       | non-strict  | 263    | 90.9%         | 96.1%       |
| schools                       | not codable | 604    | 3.8%          | 7.7%        |

*Notes:* Coverage of B3-classified project dollars among corpus-active units; regime labels PRELIMINARY. Count-based composition versions accompany every dollar-based exhibit.

**Reading.** Coverage is regime-unbalanced on the unit margin, so the text cites the count basis; both bases agree on direction.

**Table A5:** The menu matrix: non-voted share of new-money dollars

| entity type                   | non-voted \$ share | non-voted issue share | determined \$B |
|-------------------------------|--------------------|-----------------------|----------------|
| school_district               | 36.6%              | 52.2%                 | 509.9          |
| municipal                     | 88.7%              | 87.6%                 | 578.6          |
| township                      | 62.0%              | 60.7%                 | 33.7           |
| county                        | 83.1%              | 86.0%                 | 211.4          |
| special_district              | 73.8%              | 51.9%                 | 165.8          |
| authority-class issuer (memo) | 97.6%              | 92.0%                 | 124.7          |

*Notes:* National corpus, canonical new-money issues, package v3; determined dollars.

**Reading.** School districts hold the poorest exit menu; authority-class issuers barely face an electorate at all.

**Table A6:** The submerged local state

| corpus function                | project \$B | voted share | lines |
|--------------------------------|-------------|-------------|-------|
| public_hospital_facility       | 197.7       | 1.89%       | 2,404 |
| affordable_multifamily_housing | 70.0        | 1.87%       | 6,017 |
| electric_generation            | 67.1        | 0.54%       | 1,062 |
| natural_gas_utility            | 50.0        | 0.05%       | 232   |
| airport_terminal               | 48.3        | 0.25%       | 540   |
| industrial_development         | 32.6        | 0.41%       | 821   |
| senior_housing                 | 25.8        | 0.33%       | 1,087 |
| student_housing_dormitory      | 12.2        | 0.07%       | 383   |
| single_family_homeownership    | 11.4        | 0.01%       | 573   |
| charter_school_facility        | 6.9         | 0.00%       | 596   |
| recycling_waste_facility       | 6.2         | 0.34%       | 429   |
| tax_increment_project_area     | 5.5         | 1.38%       | 852   |

*Notes:* Local project functions  $\geq \$5B$  voted under 2% of the time; financing mechanics excluded; named examples in text.

**Reading.** Hospitals, housing, power and airports are financed at scale with essentially no electoral moment.



**Table A7:** Chargeable share of classified project dollars by authorisation channel

| auth mode                 | \$ch (B) | \$nc (B) | chargeable share |
|---------------------------|----------|----------|------------------|
| voter                     | 33.8     | 264.1    | 11.3%            |
| council_or_board          | 658.6    | 439.9    | 60.0%            |
| statutory                 | 183.8    | 69.7     | 72.5%            |
| refunding_no_new_election | 73.5     | 47.4     | 60.8%            |
| unknown                   | 72.0     | 34.0     | 67.9%            |

*Notes:* National corpus, classified printed-amount use lines; count-based version in Table A-C1b.

**Reading.** The voted channel finances the non-chargeable civic core; the unvoted channels carry the chargeable perimeter.

**Table A8:** Observed voted share by rule regime and entity class

| entity           | rule       | units  | voted \$ share | council \$ share | GO security share | non-chargeable share |
|------------------|------------|--------|----------------|------------------|-------------------|----------------------|
| county           | strict     | 2,375  | 23.3%          | 70.9%            | 49.1%             | 61.6%                |
| county           | non-strict | 481    | 5.4%           | 90.7%            | 80.7%             | 63.1%                |
| municipal        | strict     | 11,037 | 22.2%          | 74.1%            | 37.7%             | 34.2%                |
| municipal        | non-strict | 2,305  | 3.7%           | 89.2%            | 72.1%             | 52.6%                |
| township         | strict     | 5,735  | 18.0%          | 80.2%            | 89.3%             | 61.0%                |
| township         | non-strict | 2,483  | 46.5%          | 51.8%            | 97.1%             | 75.9%                |
| special_district | strict     | 23,373 | 33.3%          | 57.1%            | 33.0%             | 30.7%                |
| special_district | non-strict | 6,801  | 13.1%          | 83.8%            | 33.4%             | 18.2%                |
| school_district  | strict     | 12,162 | 68.4%          | 30.6%            | 85.4%             | 99.4%                |
| school_district  | non-strict | 616    | 7.4%           | 90.6%            | 45.2%             | 99.8%                |

*Notes:* Dollar-weighted shares from the entity panel (v3); rules PRELIMINARY; townships carry a proxy municipality rule (the reversal is a coding artefact scheduled for pass-2).

**Reading.** Raw magnitudes behind Table 4: under strict rules two-thirds of school dollars are voted; under lax rules almost none are.

**Table A9:** Institutional and demographic interactions with the rule (appendix)

|                           | (1)<br>Voted \$ share<br>TEL interaction | (2)<br>GO share<br>TEL interaction | (3)<br>NC share<br>TEL interaction | (4)<br>Voted \$ share<br>× homeownership | (5)<br>Voted \$ share<br>× county Dem share |
|---------------------------|------------------------------------------|------------------------------------|------------------------------------|------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|
| Strict rule (main effect) | +0.205                                   | -0.109                             | +0.005                             | +0.096                                   | +0.194                                      |
| Interaction               | -0.185<br>(0.338)                        | -1.227<br>(0.821)                  | -0.638<br>(0.494)                  | -0.047<br>(0.395)                        | -0.651**<br>(0.326)                         |
| Observations              | 396                                      | 401                                | 358                                | 13,928                                   | 13,928                                      |
| State clusters            | 34                                       | 34                                 | 34                                 | 48                                       | 48                                          |

*Notes:* Columns (1)–(3): the roughly 570-city subpanel with tax-and-expenditure-limit (TEL) stringency; the interaction asks whether TELs sharpen or blunt the rule; the subpanel is the exit-rich class where weak rule effects are predicted, so power is limited by design. Columns (4)–(5): national entity panel, strict rule interacted with the centred moderator; these moderate the first-stage channel, not the RD issuance effect (the causal moderator tests are in Section 8). Entity panel (90,604 local governments; estimation samples below are the corpus-active units for each outcome). Weighted least squares; Census-region fixed effects; controls: ln population (ln total revenue for special districts), homeownership, share 65+, racial fractionalisation, ln median household income, county Democratic presidential share 2020. Standard errors clustered by state in parentheses. The strict-rule indicator is the PRELIMINARY pass-1 coding (verification pass in progress), so coefficients read as first-stage associations, not causal estimates. \*  $p < 0.1$ , \*\*  $p < 0.05$ , \*\*\*  $p < 0.01$ .

**Table A10:** The near-miss chain

| years since failure k | maj-fail issued $\leq k$ (n at risk) | min-fail issued $\leq k$ (n) | gap   |
|-----------------------|--------------------------------------|------------------------------|-------|
| 1                     | 1.9% (n=371)                         | 4.6% (n=174)                 | -2.7% |
| 2                     | 4.9% (n=327)                         | 8.4% (n=155)                 | -3.5% |
| 3                     | 6.7% (n=326)                         | 10.3% (n=155)                | -3.6% |
| 4                     | 7.9% (n=303)                         | 12.8% (n=148)                | -4.9% |
| 5                     | 10.6% (n=303)                        | 15.0% (n=147)                | -4.4% |
| 6                     | 10.7% (n=270)                        | 16.0% (n=106)                | -5.3% |
| 7                     | 13.0% (n=270)                        | 18.9% (n=106)                | -5.9% |
| 8                     | 14.5% (n=256)                        | 20.8% (n=96)                 | -6.4% |

*Notes:* CA failed GO measures; per-cell observability restrictions; new-money issues only.

**Reading.** The near-miss deficit widens with the window: not a truncation artefact.

**Table A11:** The rate-cap split (inconclusive)

| split                                                                  | group                                | conversions | median pass→first<br>issue (y, n) | issued ≤6y of<br>pass (n) | issued ≤8y of<br>failure (n) |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------|-------------|-----------------------------------|---------------------------|------------------------------|
| A – within schools (route<br>choice – selection flagged)               | schools, 55% return<br>(rate-capped) | 118         | 4.93 (64)                         | 35.6% (104)               | 34.6% (104)                  |
|                                                                        | schools, 66.7%<br>return (uncapped)  | 9           | 9.74 (8)                          | 22.2% (9)                 | 33.3% (9)                    |
|                                                                        |                                      |             |                                   |                           |                              |
| B – cross-class (regime $\nexists$<br>entity – CONFOUNDED,<br>flagged) | schools (capped 55)                  | 118         | 4.93 (64)                         | 35.6% (104)               | 34.6% (104)                  |
|                                                                        | non-schools<br>(uncapped 66.7)       | 5           | 12.59 (2)                         | 25.0% (4)                 | 25.0% (4)                    |
|                                                                        |                                      |             |                                   |                           |                              |

*Notes:* 132 conversions; the uncapped cell (14; 9 school) is too thin to test and points against the cap story. Verdict: mechanism neither supported nor excluded.

**Reading.** Re-approved but unissued stands as a documented fact without an adjudicated mechanism.

**Table A12:** Demography of blocked majorities (descriptive; California)

| covariate                        | blocked           | cleared            | sub-50            | blocked-cleared<br>(SE) | blocked-sub50<br>(SE) |
|----------------------------------|-------------------|--------------------|-------------------|-------------------------|-----------------------|
| renter share                     | 0.370<br>(n=277)  | 0.408<br>(n=1526)  | 0.351<br>(n=161)  | -0.038 (0.006)          | +0.019 (0.010)        |
| Gini (B19083)                    | 0.442<br>(n=277)  | 0.450<br>(n=1526)  | 0.437<br>(n=161)  | -0.008 (0.002)          | +0.005 (0.004)        |
| fractionalization                | 0.538<br>(n=277)  | 0.558<br>(n=1526)  | 0.511<br>(n=161)  | -0.020 (0.010)          | +0.027 (0.014)        |
| median HH income \$              | 64,710<br>(n=277) | 68,508<br>(n=1526) | 68,344<br>(n=161) | -3,798 (1,463)          | -3,635 (2,284)        |
| 65+ share                        | 0.130<br>(n=277)  | 0.130<br>(n=1526)  | 0.142<br>(n=161)  | +0.000 (0.003)          | -0.012 (0.005)        |
| SAIPE child poverty<br>(schools) | 0.155<br>(n=107)  | 0.175<br>(n=696)   | 0.142 (n=95)      | -0.020 (0.010)          | +0.013 (0.012)        |

*Notes:* Blocked = majority short of the supermajority threshold; within-matched ACS/SAIPE at the D5 grain ladder; DESCRIPTIVE, no causal claim.

**Reading.** Blocked majorities arise in less affluent, mid-composition school districts: the incidence of the higher bar.

**Table A13:** Validation of extracted authorisation fields

| state  | T1: docs w/<br>date | exact<br>match | $\pm 7d$ | matched→PASSED | T2: voter<br>docs | supported<br>$\leq 6y$ | T3: council<br>docs | no recent passed<br>GO |
|--------|---------------------|----------------|----------|----------------|-------------------|------------------------|---------------------|------------------------|
| CA     | 779                 | 62.8%          | 64.1%    | 98.0%          | 849               | 66.4%                  | 1238                | 91.0%                  |
| LA     | 417                 | 62.8%          | 63.3%    | 86.6%          | 412               | 86.7%                  | 208                 | 79.8%                  |
| MA     | 260                 | 34.6%          | 40.0%    | 94.4%          | 1619              | 76.9%                  | 756                 | 100.0%                 |
| MN     | 209                 | 19.6%          | 19.6%    | 85.4%          | 247               | 22.7%                  | 1362                | 100.0%                 |
| NC     | 258                 | 65.9%          | 65.9%    | 98.8%          | 0                 | —                      | 0                   | —                      |
| TX     | 114                 | 73.7%          | 73.7%    | 94.0%          | 7671              | 76.8%                  | 4454                | 78.3%                  |
| WI     | 900                 | 95.4%          | 95.6%    | 87.1%          | 821               | 90.5%                  | 443                 | 86.0%                  |
| pooled | 2937                | 67.9%          | 68.8%    | 91.3%          | 11619             | 76.2%                  | 8461                | 86.1%                  |

*Notes:* Election-date matches against independently observed referenda; support and consistency tests as defined in the text. GFD bridge: 2022 public-use issuance matches GFD within 0.5% for 99.9% of bridged units.

**Reading.** Where registries are complete the extracted fields track the election record at ninety per cent or better; shortfalls sit exactly where registry coverage is known-short.

**Table A14:** County-grain partisanship (demoted from the text)

| subgroup                    | n    | $\tau$ GO-issue | SE    | z    |
|-----------------------------|------|-----------------|-------|------|
| Dem share < median (0.423)  | 5073 | +0.121          | 0.047 | 2.60 |
| Dem share $\geq$ median     | 5118 | +0.111          | 0.048 | 2.30 |
| tercile 1 (most Republican) | 3397 | +0.163          | 0.055 | 2.94 |
| tercile 2                   | 3397 | +0.072          | 0.058 | 1.23 |
| tercile 3 (most Democratic) | 3397 | +0.120          | 0.060 | 2.01 |

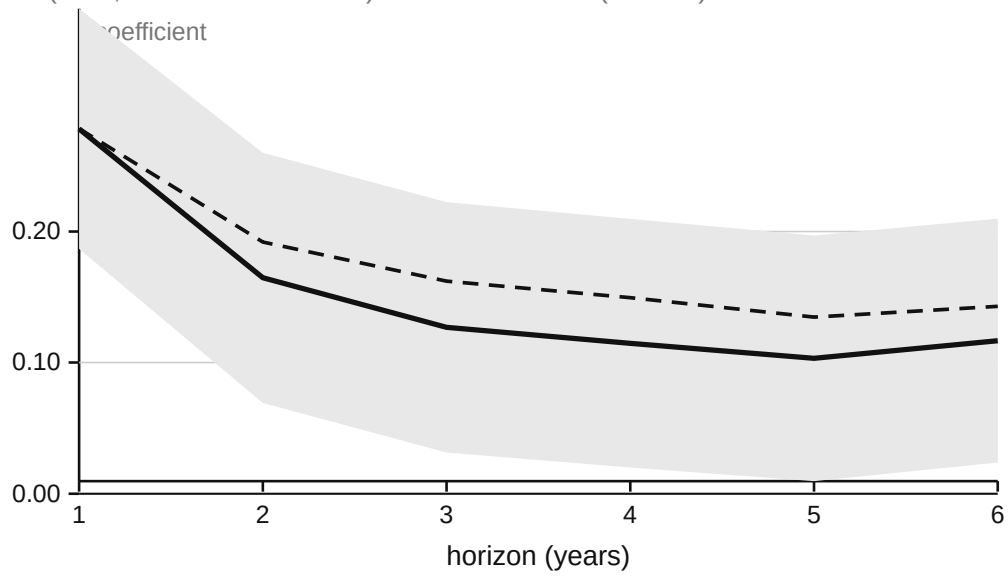
*Notes:* County presidential two-party share, 2020 vintage, county grain: a coarse proxy for district electorates. The text's partisanship null cites the precinct-built 577-city panel. National first-stage interaction: strict  $\times$  county Dem  $-0.65$  ( $t -2.0$ ), descriptive.

**Reading.** The county-grain splits agree with the city-panel null; nothing partisan moderates the authorisation effect.



## Effect by horizon

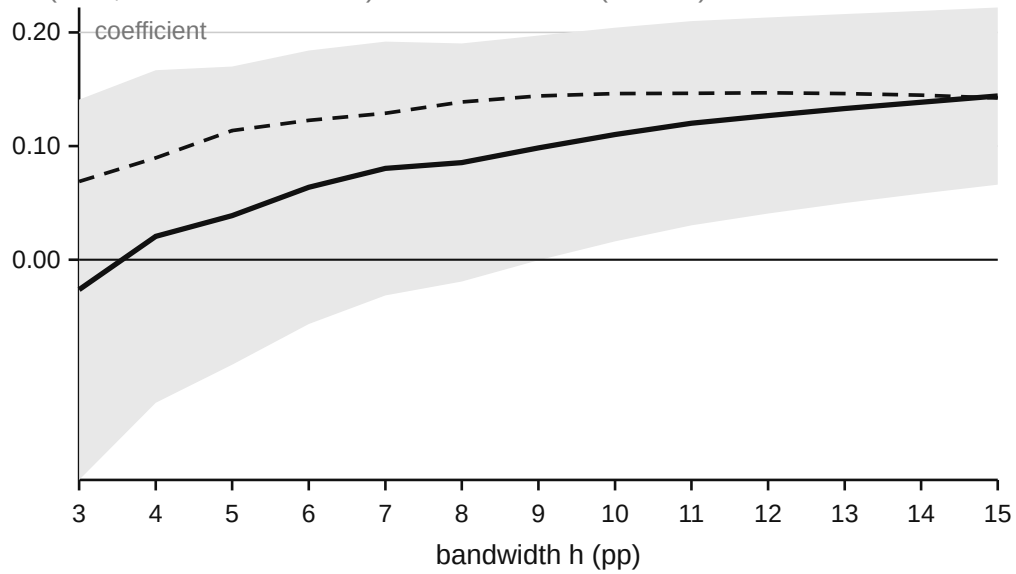
RBC (solid, with robust CI band) and conventional (dashed)



**Figure A1:** Effect by issuance horizon: RBC estimate and robust CI for windows of one to six years.

## Bandwidth sensitivity

RBC (solid, with robust CI band) and conventional (dashed)



**Figure A2:** Bandwidth sensitivity: RBC estimate (solid), conventional (dashed) and robust CI across bandwidths  $h$  of 3 to 15pp.

## Appendix H · The honesty record

*Moved verbatim from the main text per the round-3 adjudication, updated for P4/P5. The register of informative nulls, pending items and known data limits that the paper carries.*

### Informative nulls

- Partisanship (three measures, two grains: county presidential, precinct city-footprint, mayoral party): no moderation of the authorisation effect.
- The extensive margin nationally: the coded rule does not predict whether a government borrows at all, only the channel and composition.
- Entity midwifery: no detectable spawning of new issuers in refused units' counties (coarse grain, low power).
- The D2b signal test: no jump in the response at the symbolic 50% line among institutional failures.
- TEL by rule on the big-city subpanel: null, power-limited by design (large cities are the exit-rich class).
- P4 rate-cap split: the banked-authorisation mechanism is neither supported nor excluded (9 uncapped conversions; point direction opposite); the fact stands unexplained.

### Pending items, each blocking a specific claim

- Rules human pass-2 (21 cells, with the owner): C2/H2 finals; causal upgrades of the fifty-state first-stage and substitution results; the township rule column (town-meeting states break the municipality proxy).
- Proposition 39 district-level design (state matching-fund controls; CDIAC pre-2005 issuance for the composition margin): journal-version item, not to be started before the conference draft ships.
- B5 audit disagreement review (9 pairs; upgrades the 80% bridge precision).
- Ten-year-plus horizon pass on the re-approved-but-unissued cohort.
- Special-district demographics beyond county proxy (TWDB and shapefile interpolation).
- R1 reform table: secondary\_unverified pending the owner's primary-record verification.
- IL and IN vote margins (harvest scoped and paused).

### Appendix tables added in round 4

- **Table A-C1 (nc\_share selection check):** classified-amount-line coverage by state and regime, unit- and dollar-weighted (NC\_COVERAGE\_RESULTS.md). Coverage is regime-UNBALANCED on the unit margin (schools 24.1pp, general-purpose 6.4pp), so every composition exhibit reports a count-based version beside the dollar-based one; the text cites the count-based

general-purpose coefficient ( $-0.047$ ,  $t -2.25$ ) and both channel-sorting gradients (dollars 11.3/60.0/72.5; counts 17.9/34.5/54.0).

- **Table A-P1 (county partisanship, demoted from the text):** county presidential two-party splits of the authorisation effect ( $+0.121$  against  $+0.111$ ; terciles  $+0.163/+0.072/+0.120$ , non-monotone) and the national first-stage interaction ( $-0.65$ ,  $t -2.0$ ). Caveat: 2020 vintage only, county grain (a coarse proxy for district electorates). The text's partisanship null cites the precinct-built 577-city panel only.
- **Moderation-table note (all D5/H3 tables):** estimates run on the 6,255 proper-grain measures (place for cities, SAIPE/ACS district grain for schools); special districts excluded pending sub-county demographics (TWDB interpolation).
- **Fate-table labels:** "issued anyway" is split into board/statutory channel (5.2) and pre-existing voter authority (9.0); the latter is not evidence of evasion of the refused measure.
- **Version pin:** the conference draft is frozen on corpus package v3; package v4 and the B5 rerun are journal-revision items.
- **Pay-go bound cohort:** the outlay row's full-window cohort is votes through roughly 2017–18 with outlay ending at fiscal 2023.

## Known data limits, stated where used

- Louisiana parish-fold grain (outcome mixes measures within a parish).
- Minnesota school-purpose classification gap (empty E4 cell is a classification fact, not evidence).
- GFD security split (FFC/NG) unreported after 2005 for every entity type and degenerate for schools before (FFC is 100% of school long-term debt by classification); the corpus security class carries that outcome.
- GFD capital outlay: total only (construction not itemised in the compact; F-33 not in the repo); no outlay items in the 2024 public-use continuation, so outlay windows end at fiscal 2023.
- Texas BRB counts-unknown placeholder rows ("1-0", 3,188 rows) excluded from coalition-size panels; no RD estimate affected.
- Corpus truncation at 2005 (EMMA era).
- Moderator coverage is within-matched (ACS and SAIPE bridges); matched subsets are not representative of unmatched units.
- Consent-map coverage: ten states carry no determined-mode dollars (an extraction-coverage fact, shown as missing rather than imputed).

## Appendix V · Variable inventory by section (§§4–9)

Reference document, 2026-08-24, computed on the current panels (corpus package v3). "Panel" = the 40,924 crosswalked referenda; "RD frame" =  $rd\_sample \cap bond\_go$ , 11,889 measures. Coverage figures are non-blank counts from the committed files, not estimates. Conditional variables state their own denominator. British spelling; no em dashes.

### §4 · Data (identity, treatment definition, validation)

| variable                                        | definition                                                             | level                 | source                                                        | coverage                                          | notes                                                              |
|-------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------|
| unit_id / GID                                   | 9-char Census government ID (state2+type1+county3+unit3)               | unit                  | crosswalk                                                     | 40,924/47,235 referenda (86.6%)                   | exact tiers ~100% verified; fuzzy tier 95.1% RA-audited            |
| pct_yes                                         | yes share of the vote                                                  | referendum            | state registries                                              | 75% of panel; <b>100% of RD frame</b>             | IL/IN carry results only (no margin)                               |
| threshold_centered                              | margin – applicable threshold                                          | referendum            | derived; CA threshold per measure from CDIAC                  | 75% / <b>100%</b>                                 | the running variable                                               |
| rd_sample                                       | at a genuine mandatory-ballot statutory cutoff                         | referendum            | rules coding of the 9 states (direct, not the national panel) | 23,577 flagged                                    | RD-state cutoffs are bedrock statutes, outside the pass-2 worklist |
| purpose_class                                   | bond_go / bond_other / tax etc.                                        | referendum            | per-state purpose mapping                                     | 100%                                              | MN school classification gap flagged                               |
| auth_mode_final2                                | OS-evidenced authorisation mode (voter / council_or_board / statutory) | document              | corpus extraction                                             | 93.7% of docs determined (v3)                     | validated: date match 67.9% pooled, 95.4% WI; matched→passed 91.3% |
| op_referendum_strict (+ ordinal, threshold_num) | included rule, state × entity × purpose × year                         | state × entity × year | panel                                                         | 89% of panel rows; muni cell codable in 37 states | <b>PRELIMINARY pass-1; 21-cell pass-2 with owner</b>               |

### §5 · Landscape and fifty-state first stage

Grain: one row per local government (entity panel, 90,604 units) or per document (corpus).

| variable                   | definition                                             | level | source    | coverage                                   | notes                                                                                             |
|----------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|-------|-----------|--------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| nm_docs, nm_par            | new-money issues and par, 2005–25, canonical per issue | unit  | corpus v3 | 78,672 typed nm issues; 46 states ≥50 docs | 5 small states below gate (DC/DE/HI/VT/WY); 5 legacy states 72–87% flag coverage (MN/MA/MO/MD/ID) |
| sec_go_sh ... sec_sptax_sh | par shares by security pledge class                    | unit  | corpus    | where nm_par>0                             | GO / revenue / lease / special_tax                                                                |

| variable                                                                  | definition                                                   | level                             | source                                   | coverage                                                                                                                    | notes                                                                                     |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------|------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>voted_sh_par,</b><br><b>council_sh_par,</b><br><b>statutory_sh_par</b> | mode shares of determined nm \$                              | unit                              | corpus                                   | 13,875 units with a determined split                                                                                        | the first-stage outcome                                                                   |
| <b>nc_share_project</b>                                                   | non-chargeable share of classified project \$                | unit                              | B3 doc flags (118-label map, 0 unmapped) | ~18% of units                                                                                                               | classified printed-amount lines only                                                      |
| ballot purposes (M2 panel A)                                              | normalised keyword categories                                | referendum                        | 9 registries                             | 19,600 bond measures                                                                                                        | stand-in for a formal B1 taxonomy (flagged)                                               |
| votes cast / yes-needed (M3)                                              | counts and threshold $\times$ total                          | referendum                        | TX/WI/LA/NC registries                   | 7,473 GO measures                                                                                                           | CA has % only; 3,188 TX placeholder rows excluded; LA also carries voters_qualified/voted |
| GFD characteristics                                                       | pop or enrolment, revenue, own-source, property tax, LTD out | unit, latest yr $\geq 2012$       | national GFD                             | 100% of entity panel                                                                                                        | specials lack Population (revenue-size proxy in N-suite)                                  |
| ACS covariates                                                            | homeownership, 65+, fractionalisation, median income         | place (munis) / county (rest)     | ACS5-2019 national pulls                 | ~100%                                                                                                                       | county layer uniform; place upgrade for cities                                            |
| <b>county_dem2p_2020</b>                                                  | county Dem two-party share                                   | county                            | MEDSL                                    | 99–100%                                                                                                                     | 2020 only                                                                                 |
| FOG institutions                                                          | form of gov, initiative, referendum, partisan, districts     | city                              | FOG panel                                | ~570 big cities                                                                                                             | subpanel only                                                                             |
| TEL stringency; ACS-2022; city Dem; mayor party rule (per class)          | big-city extras<br><br>strict for the unit's entity class    | city<br><br>state $\times$ entity | municipal-analysis panels<br>rules panel | ~570 cities each<br><br>county 94% $\cdot$ schools 93% $\cdot$ specials 79% $\cdot$ munis 68% $\cdot$ townships 50% (proxy) | 2013-vintage TEL, no time variation<br>township column = pass-2 Part C                    |

## §6 · The RD core (frame: 11,889 GO measures)

| variable                                 | definition                                    | level      | source                   | coverage in RD frame                           | window                                                                  |
|------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|------------|--------------------------|------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>issued_6y</b>                         | any issuance $\leq 6y$                        | referendum | corpus link              | <b>100%</b>                                    | (0, +6y]                                                                |
| GO issuance $\leq 6y$                    | issued_6y $\wedge$ go_share $> 0$             | referendum | corpus                   | 100% (go_share observed for 64%, else 0-issue) | headline outcome                                                        |
| <b>nm_par_6y,</b><br><b>ln_par_pc_6y</b> | new-money par; $\ln(1+\text{par p.c.})$       | referendum | corpus + GFD denominator | 100% / 86%                                     | denominator = gfd_pop, enrolment for schools (65% of frame are schools) |
| <b>ln_gfd_ltd_pc_6y</b>                  | survey LTD issued p.c. (EMMA-independent row) | referendum | GFD + IUF FY23/24        | 73%                                            | fiscal [y+1,y+6]; IUF validated 99.9%                                   |

| variable                               | definition                                                                 | level      | source  | coverage in RD frame                                 | window                                             |
|----------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------|---------|------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------|
| capital outlay p.c. (pay-go bound row) | GFD To- tal_Capital_Outlays p.c.                                           | referendum | GFD     | 83% with a 6y window (8,489/10,244 with denominator) | ends FY2023 (IUF has no outlay); total outlay only |
| ev_m2...ev_p5                          | any nm issue in relative year k                                            | referendum | corpus  | 100%                                                 | event study                                        |
| balance covariates                     | pre-vote GFD pop, revenue p.c., debt p.c., taxes, enrolment, prior failure | referendum | GFD     | 94–98%                                               | 0/7 imbalanced                                     |
| McCrary/density inputs                 | binned margin counts                                                       | bin        | derived | full frame                                           | TX-driven excess                                   |

## §7 · The response margin (denominators are conditional)

| variable                       | definition                                                                  | level                               | source             | coverage                                                     | notes                                                              |
|--------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------|--------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------|
| resubmitted_4y hazard, KM      | same-unit+class return $\leq 4y$                                            | failed measure                      | panel sequences    | 2,680 failed GO measures (the denominator)                   | risk sets censored at registry end                                 |
| return pass / amount ratio     | outcome of the return                                                       | return                              | registries         | 1,418 returns; 1,354 with amounts                            | amounts CA/TX/WI                                                   |
| fate table categories          | converted / returned / issued-anyway / extinguished                         | failed measure                      | corpus + sequences | 1,233 (2005-19 full windows); 422 close                      | mutually exclusive                                                 |
| first-issue authoriser         | mode of first nm issue                                                      | referendum                          | corpus             | close window n=2,234                                         | transition matrix                                                  |
| continuation (B5)              | window doc sharing the ballot's purpose category                            | measure × do                        | EN2CAT bridge      | 3,854 close categorisable measures                           | bridge precision 80.0% / recall 88.9% (blind audit); re-runs on v4 |
| bundle re-composition P3 chain | categories kept/dropped on return<br>pass → first-issue timing; 8y issuance | failure → return pair<br>conversion | bridge corpus      | 1,129 pairs<br>132 CA conversions (118 capped / 14 uncapped) | uncapped cell too thin (P4 not confirmed)                          |

## §8 · Heterogeneity (moderators; split at within-frame medians)

| variable                              | definition                            | level (grain)         | source                  | coverage in RD frame                         | notes                                                                                                    |
|---------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|-----------------------|-------------------------|----------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| acs_homeown/share65+ grain/moderators | place<br>moderators                   | place<br>SD<br>county | 2,103<br>4,152<br>5,329 | ACS5<br>2010/2019<br>(pre-vote vintage rule) | 97% attached<br>proper-grain-only splits use the 6,255 place+SD rows                                     |
| sd_childpov_rate                      | district child poverty (income proxy) | school district       | SAIPE name-bridge       | 35% of frame (4,153 schools)                 | match rates vary (MN 91% ... CA 44%); within-matched validity superseded by proper grain where available |
| county mod-erators                    | 65+, frac, income (first-pass proxy)  | county                | CC-EST<br>SAIPE         | + 97.4%                                      |                                                                                                          |
| county_dem2p (pre-vote)               | partisanship                          | county                | MEDSL                   | 85.7%                                        | null result                                                                                              |

| variable                    | definition                  | level (grain)         | source                        | coverage in RD frame                                             | notes                                     |
|-----------------------------|-----------------------------|-----------------------|-------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------|
| city Dem share, mayor party | large-city par-tisanship    | city (precinct-built) | municipal-analysis            | 1,932 municipal mea-sures in 577-city panel; 178 within $\pm 10$ | replicate-the-null only                   |
| Gini (D6)                   | B19083                      | place/SD/county       | new CA pull (2010+2019) dates | CA cells (blocked-majority analysis) 100%                        | D6 is CA-only by construction             |
| election timing             | on-cycle = Nov of even year | referendum            |                               |                                                                  |                                           |
| entity class (fork)         | census_type                 | unit                  | crosswalk                     | 100%                                                             | schools 7,690 · GP 2,623 · specials 1,576 |

## §9 · Agenda margin and politics

| variable                                    | definition                           | level                  | source                           | coverage                                       | notes                                                           |
|---------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------|------------------------|----------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|
| proposals /100 districts/yr; on-cycle share | dis-ask; E4 regime comparison        | state×year             | registries + GFD district counts | CA/TX/WI (MN = classification gap)             |                                                                 |
| pass rates by regime                        | E3                                   | regime                 | registries                       | 11,888 with margins 2014–25                    | invariance at 50 vs 55; breaks at 66.7 reporting-mandate caveat |
| props/election; multi-prop share            | TX-2019 un-bundling                  | district×election      | ENBRB                            |                                                | the DiD-at-fixed-support                                        |
| W1/W2 wedge cells                           | issuance by support band × regime    | band×state×panel group |                                  | 50–55 band: CA 187 / TX+WI 653                 |                                                                 |
| reform events                               | attempts/outcomes since 1990         | state×event            | web compilation                  | 11 rows                                        | secondary_unverified (owner)                                    |
| Prop 39 / M56 DiD outcomes                  | ln per-pupil (per-capita) LTD issued | state×year             | national GFD 1997–2013           | schools $\geq 20$ districts/cell, 39–48 states | state-mean grain; district-level upgrade deferred               |

### The three load-bearing coverage facts a referee will probe

1. **RD outcomes are 100%/86% covered in-frame** (binary/intensive) and the survey replication row (73%) is symmetric across the cutoff; crosswalk selection is Lee-bounded. 2. **Moderator grains are honest**: place for cities, district for schools (SAIPE/ACS-SD), county fallback (all specials); splits are within-matched and labelled; nothing is imputed. 3. **National corpus coverage post-v3**: 46 states above the 50-doc gate; the residuals are five thin small states and five legacy partial-fill states, both listed; rule coding 68–94% by class with the township proxy flagged.